

JAPAN'S NATIONAL TREASURES

Inuyama Castle

犬山城 | AICHI, JAPAN



A small keep looking down on the Kiso River.
The smallest of the five — and the oldest.
A guide to a castle that proves size was never the point.

THE FIVE NATIONAL TREASURE CASTLES / VOLUME THREE

Before you go

Admission fees, opening hours and access arrangements described in this book are subject to change. Always check the official website for the latest information before visiting.

Inuyama Castle official site: <https://inuyama-castle.jp/>

Basic Data

At a glance

Name	Inuyama Castle (Inuyama-jo) — also known as Hakutei-jo, the White Emperor Castle
Location	65-2 Inuyama Kitakoken, Inuyama, Aichi Prefecture
Type	Architecture — castle and keep
National Treasure	Designated 1935 under the old system; re-designated 1952
The keep	Tower type — three roofs, four floors, two basement levels; about 19m tall
Founded	Said to have been built around 1537 by Oda Nobuyasu
Present form	Remodelled from 1617 onwards by Naruse Masanari

How this book is arranged

- ▶ Chapter 1 — History: how a small castle survived
- ▶ Chapter 2 — Reading the architecture: small because it is old
- ▶ Chapter 3 — Walking the castle: a route guide
- ▶ Chapter 4 — Visiting: hours, access, seasons and the neighbourhood

Inuyama is the smallest of the five National Treasure castles. But there is a reason it is small, and once you know the reason the castle looks completely different. This book goes after that reason.

History — how a small castle survived

| Built by Nobunaga's uncle

Inuyama Castle is said to have been built around 1537 by **Oda Nobuyasu**, an uncle of Oda Nobunaga. It stands on a low hill above the Kiso River, on the boundary between Owari and Mino provinces — **a place from which to watch whoever crossed the river**. The castle's purpose was tied to the river from the beginning.

| The Komaki and Nagakute campaign

In 1584, Hashiba Hideyoshi faced Tokugawa Ieyasu and Oda Nobukatsu in the **Komaki and Nagakute campaign**. Hideyoshi's general **Ikeda Tsuneoki** crossed the Kiso River and took Inuyama, which then became a key base for Hideyoshi's side.

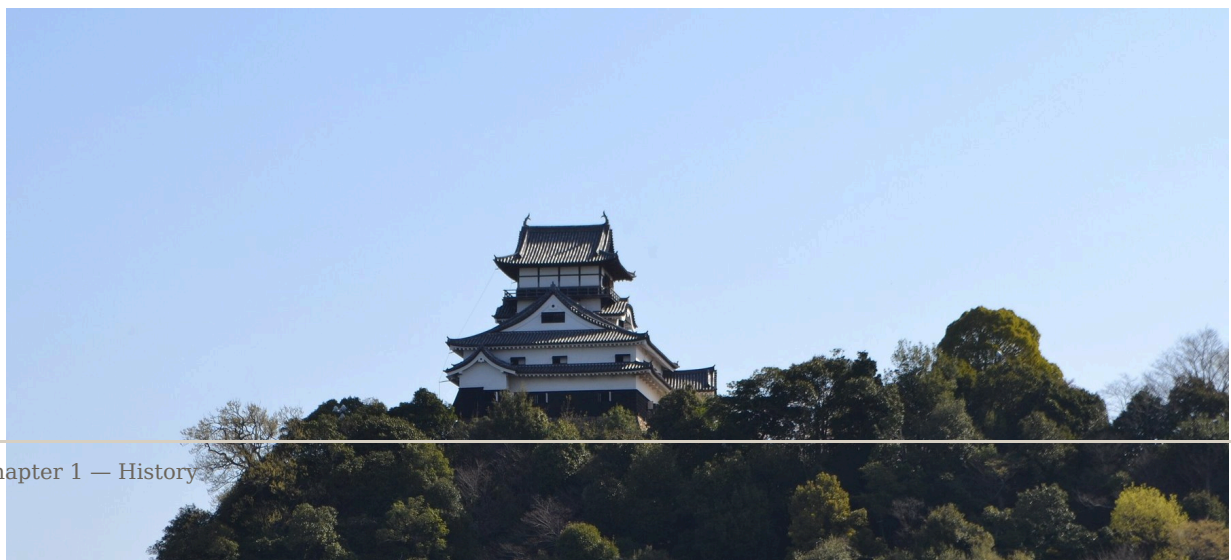
The river it was built to watch became the route by which it fell — a reminder that natural defences change meaning depending on who uses them.

| The Naruse family's castle

In 1617, **Naruse Masanari**, a senior retainer attached to the Owari domain, became lord of the castle. He rebuilt the keep substantially, giving it **the form we see today**. The Naruse family held the castle in succession until the Meiji period.

A note — the name "Hakutei-jo"

The name is credited to **Ogyu Sorai**, a Confucian scholar of the mid-Edo period. He likened the castle to Baidicheng, the "White Emperor City" the Chinese poet Li Bai wrote about on the Yangtze — casting the Kiso River as the Yangtze, an elegant conceit.



| First threat: the Nobi earthquake

After the Meiji Restoration the castle was decommissioned and passed to Aichi Prefecture. Then came the **Nobi earthquake of 1891**, an inland quake exceeding magnitude 8.0, which left **the keep half-ruined**.

The prefecture had no means to repair it. So in 1895 the castle was **handed to the former lord's family, the Naruse, on condition that they repair it**. The Naruse and the townspeople of Inuyama raised donations, and the keep was restored.

Here too, **it was the town that saved the castle**.

| The only castle in Japan owned by a private family

Inuyama thus became Naruse property, and for roughly a century afterwards it was known as **the only privately owned castle in Japan**.

In 2004 ownership passed to a foundation the family had established — now the **Inuyama-jo Hakutei Bunko Foundation** — a transfer made to sustain the castle's conservation over the long term.

| Second threat: the Isewan typhoon

In 1959 the **Isewan typhoon** struck the Tokai region. Inuyama lost roof tiles and had plaster stripped away.

Again the castle was not abandoned. The damaged keep was **dismantled and repaired over four years**, recovering the form it has today.

Earthquake and typhoon

What Inuyama survived was not war but natural disaster. Each time, the repair was taken on by the castle's family and by local people. That a small castle has stood for more than four centuries is not an accident.

Reading the architecture — small because it is old



The tower-type keep: three roofs, four floors and two basement levels. A watchtower sits on top of the hipped-and-gabled roof below. The top floor carries a railed gallery, a curved gable breaks the middle level, and the base is rough natural stone.

| The tower type — an early form

Inuyama's keep is a **tower type (borogata)**: a watchtower for looking out, set on top of a building with a hipped-and-gabled roof. The upper and lower parts read as two buildings stacked together.

This is what keeps looked like early on. Later the **layered type (sotogata)**, with floors stacked in regular diminishing tiers, became the norm. Inuyama's keep therefore preserves **the moment when the keep as a building type was still being worked out**. Set it beside Himeji's orderly connected keep and the difference is obvious.

| Rough natural stonework

The base supporting the keep is **nozurazumi** — natural stones stacked almost unworked. It looks coarse and full of gaps, and that too is an older technique.

At Himeji you can watch the craft progress towards blocks dressed to fit without a gap. Inuyama's stonework shows you **the stage before that progress began**.

| The gallery and its railing

The top floor is ringed by a **gallery** with a **railing**. Step out and the view opens: the Kiso River and the mountains to the north, the Nobi plain to the south.

But — **the railing is startlingly low**. By modern standards it feels insufficient, and more than a few visitors find their nerve tested. This too is a building from before the idea of a safety standard existed, preserved as it was.

| The Kiso River as a moat

Inuyama is small partly because **it did not need to be large**. To the north the ground falls away in a cliff to the Kiso River. No moat had to be dug, no high wall raised. **The terrain was the defence**.

Look again at the distant view on the previous page: the castle alone on its hill is the answer. Seen from the far bank, the logic is immediate.

What being small means

Line the five castles up and Inuyama is the smallest. That is not the same as being lesser. **If there are only so many directions to defend, a castle can afford to be small**. Form follows terrain and purpose rather than scale — and no castle makes that clearer.

| Compared with Himeji and Matsumoto

Castle	Keep form	Stonework	Setting
Inuyama	Tower type (early)	Rough natural stone	Cliff above the Kiso River
Matsumoto	Connected composite	Roughly dressed	Flat ground, three moats
Himeji	Connected (fully resolved)	Rough through to close-fitted	Hill (Himeyama)

Walking the castle

- ▶ The castle town — through the old merchant streets
- ▶ Sanko Inari and Haritsuna shrines — at the foot of the hill
- ▶ Up the slope and the stone steps
- ▶ The Black Gate site — into the main bailey
- ▶ The keep, basement to fourth floor
- ▶ The top-floor gallery — the river and the plain

Plan	Time	What you see
Keep only	40 minutes to 1 hour	Up the hill, up the keep, back down
Standard	About 2 hours	The keep plus the castle town
Unhurried	Half a day	Eating your way through the town, and Urakuen

Before you set off

The approach is a slope and stone steps — short, but uphill. The stairs inside the keep are very steep, and the final flight to the top floor is steep enough that the handrail matters. Carry a bag that leaves both hands free. The top floor is small and may be made one-way when busy.

What not to miss

- **The top-floor gallery** — the river and the plain. **Mind the low railing**
- **The posts and beams inside** — heavy timber left exposed; old carpentry at full force
- **The rough stone base** — look at how loosely the stones are stacked
- **The view from across the Kiso River** — where the cliff explains the castle

| The view from the top



Looking south from the top-floor gallery: the bailey's turret and gate below, then the town of Inuyama and the Nobi plain beyond. Turn north and the Kiso River and the hills come into view. What the castle was built to watch is all still within sight.

The castle was placed here for this view. It watches the boundary between Owari and Mino and the crossings of the river — a purpose that only really lands once you are standing in it.

A modern town fills the middle distance now, but the terrain has not changed. The line of the river, the spread of the plain, the ridges beyond: the same underlying shape the castle's lords looked out on.

Visiting

Admission

Open	9:00–17:00 (last admission 16:30)
Admission	1,000 yen for adults (revised March 2026)
Access inside	Open year-round; the interior of the keep can be visited
Official site	https://inuyama-castle.jp/

Fees are revised from time to time. Please check the official website before you travel.

Getting there

Nearest station	Meitetsu Inuyama Station, or Inuyama-Yuen Station
On foot	About 15 minutes from either station
By train	25–30 minutes from Meitetsu Nagoya to Inuyama
By car	Paid car parks nearby

The castle through the year

Spring	Cherry blossom on the castle hill, and along the river
Summer	Cormorant fishing on the Kiso River; the castle seen from the water
Autumn	Autumn colour and the keep — the best season for walking the town
Winter	Clear air, and the longest views from the top floor

The Inuyama Festival

Held each April at Haritsuna Shrine. Floats carrying mechanical puppets are pulled through the castle town. It is a nationally designated Important Intangible Folk Cultural Property and forms part of the UNESCO intangible heritage listing of float festivals.

| Nearby



Sanko Inari Shrine, its vermillion gates running up the steps. The right-hand pillar is carved **Naruse-ke** — the gate was dedicated by the family who held the castle.



A stone fox in the precinct, wearing a white bib, a cub beneath its paw. Foxes serve as the messengers of Inari and guard the approach.

- **The castle town** — old merchant houses along the street running south from the castle. **Grilled rice skewers and other street food** are the draw
- **Sanko Inari Shrine** — at the foot of the hill, with its tunnel of red gates and heart-shaped votive tablets
- **Haritsuna Shrine** — also at the foot of the hill; host of the Inuyama Festival

| Jo-an, a National Treasure teahouse



Jo-an, relocated to the Urakuen garden. It is attributed to Oda Urakusai, a younger brother of Oda Nobunaga.

A National Treasure teahouse in the same town as a National Treasure castle — this is the only place in Japan where that is true. Visits are by prior application and the garden closes on certain days. **Please check the official website.**

| Local food

- **Gohei-mochi** — pressed rice on a skewer, grilled with a miso glaze; the castle town's standard
- **Skewered street food** — shops along the street compete on inventive skewers
- **Miso dengaku** — the sweet-savoury miso of the Tokai region

Credits and notes

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Principal sources

Inuyama Castle official site — <https://inuyama-castle.jp/>

Aichi Now, the official Aichi Prefecture tourism site

Inuyama tourism association

Japan's National Treasures — Inuyama Castle

The Five National Treasure Castles, Volume Three

Only five castle keeps in Japan are designated National Treasures:

Himeji, Matsumoto, Inuyama, Hikone and Matsue. This series visits each of them in turn.